

Contact us

- Visit www.nationalredress.gov.au
- Phone 1800 737 377
- Contact us 8.00 am – 5.00 pm local time Monday to Friday, excluding public holidays.
- If you are calling from overseas, please call +61 3 6222 3455 and ask to speak to someone from the National Redress Scheme. Interpreter services are available when calling the Scheme.

Checklist

- ☐ Are you using a nominee? Have you completed a Redress Nominee Form - Authorising a person or organisation to ask or act on your behalf?
- ☐ Have you got copies of any Power of Attorney, Guardianship or Financial Management Order?
- ☐ Are you going to include copies of any reports or other supporting documents?
- ☐ If you have not provided your CRN / DVA File Number have you been to a Centrelink service centre?

Reminder

Free legal advice and information about redress is available through knowmore. Contact knowmore at www.knowmore.org.au or call 1800 605 762 (call charges may apply). If calling from overseas please call +61 2 8267 7400.

Please keep a copy of your application for your own records

Return your completed application

1. Scan all of your documents onto your computer
2. Log into myGov using your details
3. Select the National Redress Scheme tile
4. Select the Upload button
5. Upload all of your files
6. Select the Submit button

It is an offence to intentionally make a false statement in this application form.

Part 1

About you

Name	Richard W McLean
Other name you would like us to use when we call you?	Rich
Date of birth	8 Apr 1973

Address you live at now

Residential address	2 mccubbin st Footscray VIC 3011 Australia
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What address should the Scheme use to send you documents and letters?	Use myGov Inbox
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Eligibility

Were you under 18 years old when the sexual abuse happened?	Yes
Did the sexual abuse happen before the Scheme start date of 1 July 2018?	Yes
Was an institution responsible for bringing you into contact with the person or people who abused you?	Yes

Past steps towards redress or justice

Have you already applied to the Scheme?	No
Your Redress ID	(Not Supplied)
Has an institution already paid you damages ordered by a court?	No

Residency

Are you an Australian citizen?	Yes
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Serious criminal convictions

Have you been sentenced to imprisonment for a period of 5 years or more, in Australia or overseas, for a single offence?	No
Are you currently in gaol?	No

Phone number and messages

What is your preferred spoken language?	English
What phone number should we use to call you?	0409847076
Can we leave voice messages for you?	Yes use preferred phone number
Can we send a text to you?	Yes use preferred phone number
Is there another way to leave you a message asking you to contact us?	Yes
Organisation name	www.richmclean.com.au
Contact person	Rich Mclean
Phone number	0409847076

Your identity

What is your gender?	Male
Are you an Aboriginal Australian or Torres Strait Islander Australian?	Choose not to answer
Do you identify as a person with disability?	Yes

Confirm your identity

My CRN or DVA File Number is	305689451X
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Nominee

Do you have a Power of Attorney, Guardianship or Financial Management Order in place?	No
Would you like to appoint a nominee to act for you with the Scheme?	No

Bank account details

Branch or BSB number	063307
Account number	10140384
Account name(s)	Richard McLean
International bank account details	(Not Supplied)

Chandler primary School

Institution details

Name of institution	Chandler primary School
What type of institution was it?	(Not Supplied)
Address	Noble park VIC 3174 Australia
Other things that could help identify the institution?	I attended school here

How you were known

Name	Richard Mclean
Nick name(s)	(Not Supplied)
Other ways this institution made records about you	My sister Jodie and brother brad Mclean also attended here

Time at this institution

Dates you were at the institution	1978-1984
Age at the time the sexual abuse happened	79-81
Did you live at this institution when the sexual abuse happened?	No
When the sexual abuse happened at this institution, were you	In relative or kinship care
Did the sexual abuse at this institution happen more than once?	Yes
Over what time period did this sexual abuse happen?	More than 2 years but less than 3 years

About the person

Person 1

Name	Robert Martin
Other name(s)	(Not Supplied)
Anything else you remember that might help identify them	hard yakka shorts ugly man uncircumcised
How did they come into contact with you?	he was the father of a kid I went to school with and walked together
Do you know if they had an official role at the institution?	Not sure
Was the person under 18 years of age at the time they sexually abused you?	No

Person 2

Name	Greg Wall
Other name(s)	(Not Supplied)
Anything else you remember that might help identify them	Very feminine peer - circumcised didnt have his dad around stayed in a bungalow
How did they come into contact with you?	peer
Do you know if they had an official role at the institution?	No
Was the person under 18 years of age at the time they sexually abused you?	Yes

Describe the abuse

Bob Martin revealed his penis to me and wanted me to ...

it was uncircumcised I remember at that age only having seen my dad who was circumcised

I have a vivid memory of him talking to me and him playing with it talking to me

I was innocent but fascinate and I remember thinking 'that must be what I'll look like when I grow up'

also, I ran away and my mother used to say 'dont go to those toilets alone bad men go there'

and from an early age, I though it was me who was bad

I did not know and I carried that deeply embedded shame for 44 years

People who knew

Person 1

Name

his son

Role at the institution

student

Person 2

Name

his daughter

Role at the institution

student

Please write as much as you are able to identify anyone else who may have known

it was so odd - I had not heard from these two child peers in 20 years. I kind of lost it when I processed it all, it led to complex situations and under ruled my homelessness - but both of them on my art page on Facebook commented on it I found it very co-incidental. - too much so

Role of institutions in your life

At the time of the abuse did you live in?

Out of home care

Name of the institution responsible for the out of home care

chandler primary

At the time of the abuse did you live in?

Relative or kinship care

Name of the institution responsible for the care

neighbourhood family of children I went to primary school with

Prior payments

Have you received a payment from this institution for abuse?

No

little athletics

Institution details

Name of institution	little athletics
What type of institution was it?	sports
Address	Dandenong VIC 3174 australia
Other things that could help identify the institution?	the event happened in the toilets, I remember wetting myself on the field because I was frightened to go back. I refused to attend any more, I changed after that. Once when dad drove me home, I was so afraid to urinate that he went into a milk bar to buy a newspaper and I peed in an old McDonalds cup then I snuck out shamefully put it in the bin and was relieved when he came back and didn't notice.

How you were known

Name	richard mclean
Nick name(s)	(Not Supplied)
Other ways this institution made records about you	(Not Supplied)

Time at this institution

Dates you were at the institution	1980 1983
Age at the time the sexual abuse happened	7-9
Did you live at this institution when the sexual abuse happened?	No
When the sexual abuse happened at this institution, were you	None of these apply to me
Did the sexual abuse at this institution happen more than once?	No

About the person

Person 1

Name	(Not Supplied)
Other name(s)	(Not Supplied)
Anything else you remember that might help identify them	it was in the toilet
How did they come into contact with you?	in the toilets
Do you know if they had an official role at the institution?	Not sure
Was the person under 18 years of age at the time they sexually abused you?	Not sure

Describe the abuse

I was fearful of using the toilets because I have a blanket blank memory of something happening there

inn the last page I described how I would wee my pants, I remember my friend James defended me because another boy picked on me

I remember I hated going to little baths and I outright refused one day

I was on the way home one day as aid and busing for the toilet I peed in a McDonalds cup I couldn't hold on and I felt I needed to hide that from my dad

of course dad knew later in life when I came out I had guilt complexes about consensual sexual experience3s and my father called me a 'door watcher' they were half accepting of me being gay, dad would say of one of my gat mates 'he seems like a bloke good hand shake' in a hyper masculine way

the family then would go on holidays with siblings and partners and leave me at home

my mother father and sister attended the first mans funeral I have never named him publicly as to not ruin his old age

it had affected me profoundly over my life

I never got acknowledgentm it happened

because I had a mental illness people said was an extortionist and of course people were prejucioced that I had lost it in my early 20s

a magistrate wrote to me I was 'doomed to fail' and I could not cope

my mother started talking about him

I moved away from my family because I thought I may die and it would hurt them less

but it was not my shame to carry

then my mate died and I attempted suicide and overdosed

years later there was a violent affray already happening I intervened with - it was ro protect a member of the public

it was not because I was mentally ill

it was because I had just come from Dr MaCKinnon where we spoke of it and I literally could not bear to see injustice occur and it triggered me to protect the man and I was hospitalised

People who knew

Please write as much as you are able to identify anyone else who may have known

no one

Role of institutions in your life

At the time of the abuse did you live in?

Out of home care

Name of the institution responsible for the out of home care

little athletics Dandenong

At the time of the abuse did you live in?

Other institution

Name of the institution

Athletics club

Prior payments

Have you received a payment from this institution for abuse?

No

Part 3

Information sharing

Do you agree to share Part 3 with the relevant institution(s)?

Yes

Impact words

- Education
- Shame
- Home life
- Opportunities
- Wellbeing
- Potential
- Confidence
- Hospitalisation from injury
- Sense of self
- Relationships
- Sleep
- Permanent physical disability
- Ability to trust others
- Faith
- Sexuality
- Friendships
- Housing and homelessness
- Emotions
- Mental health
- Use of drugs and alcohol
- Sexual health
- Physical health
- Financial Security
- Life Choices
- Family
- Work

Statement of impact

I wrote an essay on it for my phd which I tried to acknowledge it but it ended up making it worse that's when I overdosed - and a negligence case was covered up I had no support networks

Psychological Injury Statement - for ComCare.

Essential to claim workers compensation

Dr Richard William McLean,

Date of Statement: (16/05/2021).

1. I was sexually abused in my childhood by a neighbor, Bob Martin. (He was an adult).
2. I always remember what happened but did not acknowledge, identify, or voice it to anyone. It had been my experience and you only get one experience a lifetime so, I kept it hidden from myself, and hidden from other people including making it unconscious to myself.
3. (date) I began my research doing a PhD and I was surprised at how little distressed the students were, compared to my distress, and I began to acknowledge the abuse to my GP and my psychologist.
4. I needed to confront the sexual abuse, and I did it via the vehicle of writing. It became part of my PhD, and I gave a speech of it on (date) at The State Library of Victoria. The next day the conference went on which I was expected to attend - but I was cocooned in my bed.
5. For months the sexual abuse troubled me, and in (date) I saw injustice occurring at The dancing g Dog Caf on ANZAC day. Fresh from discussing the abuse and triggered by the memory, reflecting on my life and how it was complicit in every decision - I abandoned my Buddhist philosophy of 'no violence', and when faced with a situation that I thought the victim may be killed, I was punched and my anger which was a metaphor for the injustice I experienced as a sexual abuse survivor - manifested in me defending myself. An affray occurred, and I was hospitalized with broken bones and sutures in my face/lip.
6. My first experience with VOCAT: I make a complaint yet I am awarded a bare minimum - VOCAT considered me a 'primary aggressor', even though this was factually incorrect by a long shot.
7. I receive the lowest form of compensation, and the offenders are never found, despite the video footage. I requested the Police for my FOI under FOI legislation with the intention of clearing my name, via the video evidence, should I ever be pulled over.
8. the video was never forthcoming or released under FOI. At that time, I am writing my journals on the sexual abuse framed by working with young people for my PhD yet could not write because I was in plaster.
- 9.
10. (Date) I attempted suicide with an overdose of medication. In the suicide note, it mentions the abuse by not one but another peer abuser in grade four - and the fact my own mother did not believe me about my neighbor. I am distressed and angry, yet somehow, I survived. (Reference suicide note).
11. Unknown to me that this would be the beginning of an endemic and (x) conspiracy that not one organization could intervene in - I have a rational paranoia, because my former partner was also a sexual abuse survivor and he was employed by ASIO, and he admitted 'looking me up' by my phone number yet I was not on their radar.
12. After the suicide attempt, I moved to Ocean grove where I gained certification as a registered therapist for the NDIS, as a backup plan for if/when I returned to Melbourne and for gainful employment after my PhD.
13. I made a detailed report to police at Geelong, framed by the Pell case that was on television at the time. It encouraged the survivors to speak up and for the sake of any other children that may be at risk, I named my neighbor as the person responsible for the sexual abuse in my report to the police.
14. I attempt to get an apology or conciliation from the GP who gave me the drugs when I explicitly told him I was suicidal, via the Health Complaints Commissioner. (Recording).
- 15.
16. A VOCAT lawyer was hired to oversee my sexual abuse case
17. I move back to Melbourne, oddly into the exact same house. I decide to sleep in the opposite room that I had tried to suicide in, and start my new life blending my love of art and advocacy framed by secular ethics.
18. I continue work on my PhD and begin work as a therapeutic support explicitly for clients on the NDIS. I submit my invoices through PRODA, who pays my wage.
19. (Date) I met a client of mine Michael Forbes. He was a sexual abuse survivor and had a mental illness. He was a client of the NDIS and I was an NDIS Provider. I was paid as under the category of 'therapy other' (rate).
20. I am paid into my account by the NDIA after I submit my invoices through PRODA, a government portal for NDIA managed clients.
21. On (date) I am given a bill for an advance payment that was advanced to me because of the effect of COVID, and I have an ID and provider number through PRODA and it is from the NDIA.
22. From (date) to (date) I counselled Michael Forbes and his horrific life that had its genesis in the child rapes and incest and the lasting effect this had on his entire life

23. From (date) to (date) I exchanged hundreds of emails with my VOCAT lawyer(s), about my own sexual abuse case and my representative at that firm was changed again and again. It took nearly 3.5 years to prepare a case before the magistrate. The date was set to be (date)
24. (Date) under much duress and time amplified and triggered by Michael's experiences - my VOCAT case was heard before magistrate (name) all this time I am preparing Michael's VOCAT statement to be acknowledged by a Justice of The Peace for his application for compensation.
- 25.
26. I anxiously awaited an outcome, it came with a phone call from (name) - it had blown over in court and was thrown out; yet I was never given an email or letter confirming the outcome, which was unethical and illegal.
27. YourLawyer.com.au did not give concrete evidence of an outcome only verbally on the phone
28. I found out that because of COVID the magistrates hearings were recorded. On date(s) I contacted Geelong Magistrates court to repeatedly ask for a copy of the recording because YourLawyer.com.au refused to give anything concrete
- 29.
30. (date) The magistrate wrote me a PDF I begged her for, it stated 'I was doomed to fail', colorful language to utilize for a sexual abuse survivor.
31. From (date) to (date) I listened to Michael Forbes and the sexual abuse he endured from various people.
32. On (date) I compiled a synopsis that Michael could sign off on for the purposes of VOCAT in his own case he was hoping to be compensated for. His lawyer I organized was (name) from (location).
33. On these dates I communicated with a Lawyer I found Michael (insert dates)
34. On this date I communicated with Michael's plan manager 9s0 which changed over time: (insert dates), as I continued to provide Michael with support.
35. The consistent triggering of the memories of my own abuse by Michael's story and the stress of VOCAT and never being acknowledged by anyone including from a court by the magistrate as an adult - meant I had a highly distressing time, and triggered me sustained with the constant triggering of Michael's story to breakdown.
36. On 22nd Jan 2021 or there abouts I was unable to attend work and with interacting with Michael - as it was negatively impacting me on a deep psychological level. The trigger was the content of a CD that came in the mail from the magistrate of the hearing. I knew if I listened to it - it would confirm the outcome - that I was never believed, and it was thrown out of a court of justice, and I am gutted and outraged.
37. Michael was my longest client and I knew him very well. I could not bare to see him, or interact with him because of the reminders he would give in his account of the sexual abuse, and his life which had been shattered. I compared it to mine, I had moved 24 times in my life, always 'running', from an 'invisible' enemy, yet I now knew the main catalyst for all my worldly problems and it was not believed and not validated, despite me being so compassionate in Michael's defence.
38. and in this way the deep thought I had placed in Michael and the many many hours we had communicated, the synopsis of his life framed by his sexual abuse I made for his VOCAT lawyer, the deep reflection of writing 'Giving Up the fags' about my own experiences, for my PhD, caused the psychological injury - I was unable to face Michael anymore.
39. I was disabled from work after that.
40. Only a few more hours were worked from home as an honouring of Michael's needs because he claimed he wanted to speak to me. I also on (date) and (date) organized the handover of Michael's VOCAT case, his lawyer, his support co-ordinator, to get them all on the same page for Michael's continuing care in my absence.
41. In the meantime, I begin to believe there is a 'conspiracy' to silence a non-malicious recording I had of the original GP as evidence for the health Complaints Commissioner. Implicated in no particular order of denying what I saw as clear case of medical malpractice and professional negligence were the following institutions and organizations:
42. Saw my GP on (date) and he filled out an insurance form, putting down that my 'injury' and distress was acutely work related and that the 'injury' manifested as a result of the negative legal outcome of my own sexual abuse case. He had ten minutes to fill out the form.
43. On (date) I applied for income assist with my private insurer (include this?) but was denied.
44. The case went to AFCA, and the insurer watched my distress grow as I needlessly became bereft of money and began squatting with only Jobseeker to support me, which did not even cover 75% of my rent.
45. My insurer, deny my claim after many may calls, stating I have a 'psychological injury' and that general 'stress' is a 'mental illness'. They state that they will not pay, the income assists unless I have a workers compensation claim for the same injury - I am unaware that I may indeed, be covered by WorkCover.
46. On (date) my father becomes distressed about my mental state that was fuelled by me not working nor being acknowledged for my sexual abuse despite me vigorously advocating for others.
47. (Date) I am hospitalized at Weribbee mercy psychiatric hospital ward.
48. After three days in there, compounded by being 'too mad' or 'not mad enough', I attempt suicide after my medication I believe was, maliciously withdrawn by the treating psychiatrists for nearly four days from me, and my dog was left alone for four days in my home I was squatting in.
49. In the FOI about that incident, The Mercy Hospital notes the act was 'fatal' and I 'had no observable pulse', after I slit my artery intending to die.

50. (Date) My sister visits me in hospital, and she informs me that the man who sexually abused me, has passed away. I feel nothing, and try and forgive him, and the life it manifested for me. I am confused and don't give it any thought - being stoic and focusing on getting out of hospital.
51. My parents attend the funeral of my abuser whilst I was recovering from my second suicide attempt whilst under duty of care of the hospital.
52. I tell the staff at the hospital there is a conspiracy to ruin me, and before I was admitted I began publicly stringing all the injustices together on my website.
53. The reaction to my conspiracy theory was to dope me up on anti-psychotics. In actual fact, the discharge notes from Dr Lagasso, directly state no psychosis is present, and that I am simply not delusional. My somewhat 'paranoid' beliefs are validated by the psychiatrist in that statement.
54. He diagnoses 'adjustment disorder'. My fears of being the unwitting center of a movement to rob me of prosperity and watch as I died of my own hand before measures of any prosperity or compensation for what I saw were Human Rights injustices and crimes, are confirmed via the hospital exit statement.
55. On (date) I called WorkCover and they told me every worker is covered, so I got the workers cover certificates from my GP who was across my distress, and submitted it to workcover with their form. WorkCover referred me to Comsure who was apparently my insurer even as a sole trader but as the NDIS paid my wage I considered that this be the appropriate place to go and place my claim.
56. Presently due to the conspiracy and great misfortune I suffer flashbacks to be abuse and enraged my parents would attend his funeral. Fresh in my memory is the person Michael Forbes - whose life I intimately heard and witnessed it impacting his life.
57. The conspiracy continues; on my hospital discharge I am referred to Salt Water Clinic in Footscray. It takes me around twenty days to gain traction with anyone there.
58. (Date) before I went into hospital I had a fight with my psychiatrist who was aware of the first GP complaint to the Australian medical review Board. He confirms he has been colluding with another GP I had before Dr Moore.
59. The GP also knew of my distress and lack of support regarding the sexual abuse, and I shared the conspiracy with him in the hope it may lead him to act, as I was desperately seeking validation. Instead, I had hurt my back, and he had me on two boxes of Endone at a time, remarkable for a survivor of suicide who had overdosed on opioids my prior GP gave me. When I did not die, he withdrew the valium and endone I was taking and berated me to apologise to staff for sending upsetting emails, and to attend drug and alcohol counselling as a condition of being a client - that is when I changed my GP to Dr Richard Moore who is my current GP.
60. In nearly three months, Salt Water Clinic refuse medication I have a diagnosis for, despite evidence from my former psychiatrist. They have never offered me a psychologist nor a psychiatrist to date-extraordinary way to treat a suicide survivor who tried to kill themselves in Mercy hospital - however this clinic is an extension of that hospital, and I believe that they hope I will die as well before justice. I believe this to be part of the conspiracy.
61. (date) I do not qualify for disability support pension because of (reason) even though I was on it from (date) to (date) before I started my business. As of today's date, I am on Jobseeker and denied my prior DSP.
62. As I depend on my brother to pay my rent, some of my family abandon me, and as I go through the motions of making my workcover claim, I am directed to Amy, who tells me that I am not fitting of the requirements to be covered under comsure. I am rationally paranoid by this stage, and record calls. In an email dated (date) she tells me I am unsuitable but I defend myself and ask her to urgently intervene when I sent her this response: (date).
63. In my confusion, I make the claim anyway because I have a reference number at Comsure. I become aware a 'psychological injury' is complex and I prepare this statement on how nearly two years triggered in particular by Michael Forbes he unwittingly in conjunction with my 3.5 year fight and suicide attempts and being the unwitting centre of a conspiracy, aware that the conspiracy has already attempted to deny me of this just compensation for psychological injury.
64. I plan to prepare a semi private/public report on the injustices of my life and the ill will wished upon me with the aim of stripping me of dignity, prosperity, freedom, mark me as 'insane' which is an easy avenue to exploit despite me getting a Doctorate, and conspiracy to pervert the course of justice by many thousand of people commanded by an agency invested in my demise for the information I know and the proof I have of this injustice.
65. In the grief of being ill from work fuelled by the parallel tragedy of my life like Michael's, I confront the idea of working again. I was so proud to be a part of, my father has unintentionally ostracized me from working for the NDIS via my way of incarceration, and I have gone bankrupt for my debts; insolvency is not allowed under NDIA guidelines without a legitimate excuse.
66. Today I write this statement. (16/05/2021).

and also this article

Critical Autoethnography Speech, Art & Activism, presented on 13th of July, 2017, State Library, Victoria.

My name is Rich Mclean and I am studying my PhD in the College of Education at Victoria University Melbourne.

Thanks for coming to pay attention and also validation, as you will hear, to my short talk.

I'll introduce from a quote from Springgay, from the handbook, 'Being with Autoethnography', (my methodology), where she writes there is 'no need to separate the personal from the professional any more than we can separate the dancer from the dance'. (Springgay, pp5). Hopefully, by the end of this short talk, you will see why that is important to me in terms of critical autoethnographical and autobiographical, practice led writing and research.

I am working with young people for my PhD. Specifically, year eleven students. 'What will it mean to be human through the lens of technology in the near future?' is the broad central theme.

I am writing a six-week curriculum exploring artificial intelligence, and the anticipated superintelligence that will further enable transhumanism. What do young people ethically think of living in a post-human world?

But that is not what this talk is about.

In my youth and adolescence, I felt had no non-prejudiced person to validate my emotional or ethical life. As a forty-four-year-old adult myself, I want to be that person for these kids, allowing them to voice their concerns and for them to be heard.

My intuition that led me to be wanting to work with young people is multifaceted and as it turns out, complex. In the first instance, I have worked with young people before discussing mental health issues (as per my lived experience of 'schizophrenia'), and drug use and abuse in many pedagogical settings in the past. I have valued and enjoyed hearing young people's candidness. I also have no children of my own.

For my presentation, I would like to read an abridged and sometimes for me emotional introduction to my exegesis. Through auto ethnographical and autobiographical, practice led writing it has led to some intensely personal and stunning revelations. I feel this adds to my justifications of working with young people and needed to be addressed before my research commenced.

Just before I start this narrative piece I would like to quote (Jones), that: 'Autoethnography uses the researcher's personal experiences as primary data.'

'GIVING UP THE FAGS'

Just before Christmas in 2016, (fairly recently), I gave up smoking. This was for health reasons, as I was getting unfit and short of breath. Another reason was to avoid feeling ostracized with the proliferation of non - smoking zones. Being ostracized is also a feeling I have felt throughout my life. It was also to save money and have literally have enough prosperity so that I could put a roof over my head to finish this PhD.

I only expected to give up smoking. What happened next was totally unexpected. It is a bit like the outcome of this novella I am writing for my PhD, for the result is beyond an event horizon in which no one knows the outcome.

The occurrence of giving up smoking however, wove itself into this PhD narrative and is a vehicle by which I can place my more self-actualised identity within the framework of my study.

It also goes part way to justify why it is that I want to work with young people, apart from the fact they are familiar with technology and will inherit this fast changing technological world.

As a young 'queer' person with a mental illness, I did not think I ever received much validation. I did not have the capacity nor the opportunity to express myself in many ways, and with the onset of depression, addiction and psychosis, that coupled itself with isolation and ostracisation, I did not ever have the opportunity to.

This being said I had wonderful parents in many ways growing up and other well-meaning relatives around. However, growing up in the eighties AIDS crisis, to feel like anything other than heteronormative was difficult. The television broadcast the shock tactics of the Grim Reaper killing people with AIDS. Adults and children alike, had eyes and ears during my formative years. We had a close family, they were all wonderful - but to be gay - that was bad.

I recall Mum at the park when I was young, 'Don't go near those toilets without me, bad men go there'. Mum was caring and expressing herself from a well of love and protectiveness. She was a great Mum.

With my developing self-awareness, I further want to be a non-prejudiced and open person for young people to relate to with candidness and openness.

When I gave up smoking, unconsciously I went into self-destruct mode for a while, a sort of self-medicating and hedonistic coping mechanism. After some months, it suddenly dawned on me - that I had undergone inappropriate sexual abuse and sexual exposure when I was a child.

I was 'exposed' to, and also witnessed things of a sexual nature from two abusive peers that I need not have seen. I had also been flashed at and was shown an adult's genitals by someone very close to my home whom I and the family trusted.

The memories started to rush in - at another separate event, I can't quite remember and don't want to, an incident occurred at the toilets at little athletics when I was about eight years old. I only put weight to this sketchy memory, because even though I loved little aths and was good at it-I never went back after the 'incident' despite my father's pleas.

After that incident at little aths, I remember being so scared of, and avoiding the toilet so much, that I recall going home one afternoon from little aths having not urinated all day and Dad popping into the milk bar to buy the paper as he used to.

Having avoided the scene of the indecency, I could not hold on anymore, so I pissed in a McDonalds cup in the front seat of our family Volkswagon, snuck out of the car and put it in the bin, before Dad came back, such was my shame.

Bad people go there. To be gay was bad. This meant that I was bad. This was ingrained from a young age.

I carried that guilt and shame for most of my childhood, all my adolescence and adult life.

I had always remembered the abuse, yet I did not ever consciously give it voice, or gave it any weight. However, as I wrote more, additional memories came back for which I received counsel from my psychologist. For the longest time, my whole life in fact, I had made decisions as an adolescent and an adult that had their genesis in the non-validation of the abuse.

This included drug taking, risky behavior, constantly changing the location of where I lived, 'running away', squatting in disheveled housing at times, being jobless, not confident and not knowing why, financially bereft, emotionally traumatized, and overactive sexual misadventures.

It also manifested in choosing life partners and company in which I settled for, yet deserved much more. I have no doubt that my self-denial of what had happened to me added to and exacerbated my diagnosis of schizophrenia from age twenty over my lifetime.

Smoking for me was literally a smokescreen for nearly 23 years.

It was the reason not to remember, the affirmation that I as a person was not worthy. I did not care for myself. At the start, it was rebellious; it was also something I started to do when I was young that I knew I was not allowed to: that was taboo. I as a young person, had known taboo with abuse and prejudice-but the taboo of smoking was something that I myself was in control of.

This was in antithesis, of the abusive and inappropriate events that happened to me growing up; of the face of being vulnerable and exposed, and then not having the opportunity to express or validated what had happened.

Smoking was also a reason to die.

Such was my lack of self-esteem, I knew it would kill me - it said so on the pack! This self-depreciative beast took over my life from age thirteen.

It had become my addiction and best friend. It was a smokescreen for the memories that I had pushed deep into the wells of my sub consciousness. I remember throughout many psychosis and depressive episodes in my adolescence and adulthood, wanting and wishing I could die.

There was also a couple of brazen attempts, which thankfully did not work.

Ethnographically, on our televisions and on the news, gay people died of AIDS. Even in primary school, I had crushes on the boys, and crushes on the girls. What if I was gay? Maybe I deserved to die? have another smoke!

I did not really answer that question of 'Was I gay?' with certainty and confidence until I was twenty-five, had moved out of home, and got myself a job as an artist and illustrator for a major Melbourne newspaper. I needed a place to be safe when I finally did come out.

Smoking the fags meant:

I did not deserve to live (because it would kill me),
or be prosperous, (because it cost so much).

Then I gave them up.

A change occurred that made me feel like I was a worthy person. I uncovered all the memories of the sexual abuse, of the complex family relationships within a complex time and how this had manifested into my adult life.

This surprising re-birth happened fast.

Giving up the fags was a journey of healing, and this short speech is a testament to that. It is the process of owning your experiences (both conscious and sub conscious) and being responsible, for your greatest happiness, and highest good.

To be a self-actualized adult you must be aware of your history, your make-up and your relationships and your memories, and be fully conscious of it - yet for me, the illusion of the smoke screen of smoking kept me from this.

In essence-to validate and be reborn from a troubling past I had to confront the self within an autobiographical and autoethnographic narrative. This is the essential practice led writing that has un-blocked me from moving forward within my PhD and within my personal life.

This public statement, writing and talking both frees me and also encourages my future happiness, and dare I say prosperity and security in a multitude of ways. This is the piece of writing, and the public testimony, that exalts me and sets me free. It will also make me a better teacher and more self-actualized researcher.

My psychologist wrote something down for me a couple of months which I said which he skillfully reminded me of:

31/01/2017

'I deserve a future',

'I deserve a life',

'I am worthy'.

I deserved, to be heard, and to live with wealth happiness and prosperity.

Giving up the fags was a revelation, yet late at age forty-four. However, I am sure we all know some people don't make it. But to feel self-worth and be listened to??

This is what the young people in my PhD study, and young people everywhere, deserve to feel. We owe it to them as mentors, parents, and teachers.

So, I am no longer a smoker. (I do still vape though). This speech has been important to me as a public statement because I rightly and justly claimed my worth back.

These were the words I needed to say which came from me and no one else, in order to move forward with my autobiographic writing of reflecting on being a young person, so I can be of service to my students and go on to co-contribute to produce global knowledge from local settings.

These challengingly spoken words of intimacy and trauma had existed kicking and screaming in sub liminality - right up into and strongly influencing my adult life.

This writing, my decisions, and this speech is a release, a healing, a process, a validation. Also, a manifesto of sorts for the role I will play in listening and validating young people's concerns in terms of my PhD topic.

If I could right now, I'd take a drag on my vape, and I'm on my way.

Thank you for reading/listening.

ON CRITICAL AUTOETHNOGRAPHY:

To quote an early text from C. Wright Mills (1959) from Joneses 'Handbook of autoethnography, before the term autoethnography existed:

'The sociological imagination enables us to grasp history and biography and the relations between the two in society. The challenge is to develop a methodology that allows us to examine how the private troubles of individuals are connected to public issues and to public responses to these troubles. That is its task and its promise. Individuals can understand their own experience and gauge their own fate only by locating themselves within their historical moment period, (pp. 5-6, slight paraphrase)¹
(Jones 123)

Jones, Stacy H. Handbook of Autoethnography. Routledge, 2016 0523. VitalBook file.
Furthermore Carolyn Ellis (2004) defines autoethnography as "research, writing, story, and method that connect the autobiographical and personal to the cultural, social, and political" (p. xix).

Please share this article if it resonated with you. Thank you.

Supports you used

Name	Dr Robert Mckinnon
Position	Psychologist
Organisation	(Not Supplied)
How did they help you?	(Not Supplied)

Declaration

I declare that:

- the information I have provided in this form is complete and correct.
- I have read and understood the Information Sharing and Privacy Notice provided in this Application for Redress.

I understand that:

- I must notify the National Redress Scheme if any of my circumstances change.
- the National Redress Scheme can make enquiries with myself and relevant institutions to assist my application process.
- giving false or misleading information, documents or statements to the National Redress Scheme is a serious offence and penalties may apply.

Declaration accepted and application submitted on 21 May 2022